

SWIPE, STRESS, STUCK: EXPLORING PEOPLE'S ATTITUDES ABOUT
ONLINE DATING AS OBSERVED IN REDDIT AND SURVEY RESPONSES

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Abstract

Dating apps have grown into a multibillion-dollar industry, but it's not without widespread criticism and prevalent user dissatisfaction, raising questions about the complex relationship between platforms and their users. This study examines how dating app users conceptualize online dating and navigate safety concerns by employing two complementary data sources: a survey of 175 Cornell students with experience with dating apps and 5,833 Reddit posts scraped from 10 dating-related subreddits. Using metaphor analysis, Likert-scale questions, keyword-based sentiment analysis, VADER, and GoEmotions, the study uncovered a consistent pattern across both datasets: users experience harm, rationalize it, sustain an illusion of control over algorithmic outcomes, and continue engaging with the platforms. Consistent with prior literature, market and game-related metaphors dominated how users described online dating. However, a significant percentage of users (23.88%) resorted to labor metaphors, revealing a psychological toll that intensifies with increased duration of platform use. Though 52% of survey participants reported experiencing at least one form of harm, 71% had never reported any incident to platforms. Sentiment analysis of Reddit posts highlighted that returning users consistently expressed higher negative sentiment across all three classification methods. Together, these findings support the *Circle of Harm Tolerance*, a framework describing how users cycle through harm, rationalization, and reengagement in platforms, and this cycle is sustained by an illusion of control, which may be reinforced by platform and third-party services.

This study suggests that underreporting reflects a rationalization process in which the user redirects accountability inward rather than toward platforms. This has implications for platform design, safety intervention, and user well-being.

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1. Introduction

As of March 2026, Tinder has 500M+ downloads in the App Store. For more than a decade, it has been the most popular dating app. Owned by the same parent company, Match Group, Hinge has had 10M+ downloads. These platforms have built a sophisticated, scalable business on a freemium model, offering different tiers of subscription like Hinge Plus and Tinder Gold. They also have in-app one-time purchases designed to increase visibility. On these platforms, users curate a profile and engage with matches recommended by increasingly sophisticated algorithms due to advances in machine learning and AI. However, beneath these sophisticated business models and algorithms lies a tension that is unique to this industry: these platforms, by design, are built to be deleted. Unlike other subscription products like Netflix and Spotify, where retention and user success are parallel, for dating apps, these two goals are almost orthogonal. They succeed when their user eventually leaves the platform. One way of analyzing this tension is by questioning if these companies are delivering what they promise, but the more fundamental question is, how can a sustainable business be built around a promise that ends the relationship with your consumer?

Criticism about dating apps is not new (Strubel & Petrie, 2017; Finkel et al., 2012; Thomas et al., 2025). A study published in 2017 (Strubel & Petrie, 2017) showed that compared to non-users, Tinder users reported less satisfaction with their face and body and had stronger internalization of societal appearance ideals. Beyond the impact on self-image, literature also raises questions on whether access to potential partners leads to a relationship. Finkel et al. (2012) argue that

access acquired by users through dating apps alerts people about the existence of potential partners, but the awareness of access alone might not necessarily lead to any face-to-face encounter. This gap between access and connection gets compounded with the increase in the volume of options, as users may experience information overload. A study on decision-making on dating apps argues that, as the number of options increases, individuals may experience choice overload, choice dissatisfaction, and increased switching likelihood (Thomas et al., 2025).

However, despite the evident user dissatisfaction and widespread criticism, the global online dating market size was estimated at USD 9.65 billion in 2022 and is projected to reach USD 17.28 billion by 2030 (Grand View Research, n.d.).

This disconnect between general opinion about dating apps and the expanding market size highlights that there is a need to explore the relationship between the platform and its users. As the use of algorithmic matching expands with new AI-driven dating platforms, such as Known, entering the landscape (Known, n.d.), it is important to explore how users conceptualize online dating and navigate their concerns around platform safety. This study aims to explore the opinions of dating app users by focusing on the following two questions:

1. How do users conceptualize online dating in an age of AI?
2. What kind of safety issues do users face, and how do they deal with them?

To answer these questions, the study employs two complementary data sources: a survey of Cornell students and Reddit posts across 10 dating-related subreddits. Since the study aims to explore people's opinions about dating apps, a survey of Cornell students yields reflective data

from young dating app users, and Reddit offers a more real-time expression of dating experience from a wider range of people, who are likely posting on Reddit about their experiences as they are going through it. Converging findings across both groups strengthen the credibility of any emerging patterns.

This study focuses on the English-language discourse about dating apps by drawing insights from a survey of Cornell students and posts in dating-related subreddits. It does not aim to be representative of all dating app users, but rather to surface patterns in how users conceptualize and experience these platforms.

2. Literature Review

The disconnect between the widespread criticism of dating apps and their continued market growth indicates that there is a complex relationship between users and platforms. Understanding this complexity requires closely examining existing literature to unpack how users conceptualize dating apps, how they are affected by online dating, and how they navigate these spaces. This review explores those questions by focusing on five themes: how users conceptualize dating apps, the emotional experience of being on the platform, the safety concerns they encounter, how they rationalize harm and display agency, and what keeps them on the platform.

2.1 Conceptualization of dating apps

Use of the marketplace metaphor for online dating is common and well-researched (Ahuvia & Adelman, 1993; Baker, 2008; Heino et al., 2010). Literature argues that the marketplace

metaphor has two dimensions: the first is the consumption metaphor, where a user has options, and the second is the selling metaphor, where the user is trying to present themselves as the best possible option for others (Ahuvia & Adelman, 1993). The use of economic metaphor predates online dating and is generally used for any mate selection process (Heino et al., 2010). Later, online dating further encouraged commodification as users engaged in constructing their profiles to attract others (Heino et al., 2010; Arvidsson, 2006). Online dating platforms have technical affordances like filtering, detailed demographic information, and increased access, which makes market metaphor salient in understanding the initiation of intimate relationships (Heino et al., 2010). Users engaging in the market have an expectation to meet “quality singles”, which motivates them to pay subscription fees and participate in self-presentation online (Arvidsson, 2006).

Engagement in actions like swiping, profile viewing, and writing bios to catch someone’s attention also makes people think of online dating as games (Huang et al., 2022). Even though a 2022 study on folk theories about online dating shows that games are metaphors unique to online dating (Huang et al., 2022), a 1992 study about the root metaphors in romantic relationship development saw games as a metaphor for relationship development, with themes around chasing (Baxter, 1992).

2.2 Emotional experience of dating app use

While metaphors help users conceptualize online dating with a known concept, like shopping or games, literature also discusses the emotional experience people have with the use of dating apps. According to a survey done by the Pew Research Center in 2020 (Anderson et al., 2020),

users of online dating platforms face both positive and negative aspects of the platforms, as 57% of online daters say that they have overall positive experiences with dating platforms, while simultaneously 45% of current users also say that using the platforms made them feel frustrated. Literature that covers the positive aspect of online dating tends to highlight aspects of access and organization (Schwartz & Velotta, 2018; Havey, 2021). They also create space for LGBTQ users to explore and learn about their sexual identities (Havey, 2021). In 2022, Sobieraj and Humphreys found that dating app users often treat the experience as a source of entertainment, discussing it with friends, sharing stories about their use, and sometimes using the apps together in group settings (Sobieraj & Humphreys, 2022).

Literature that focuses on negative aspects of dating apps tends to focus on choice overload and how profile abundance can overwhelm users (Thomas et al., 2025). While metaphors like shopping imply access and abundance of options, literature argues that this access also backfires (Thomas et al., 2025, 2022). The availability of a high number of potential partners increases the fear of being single and decreases self-esteem (Thomas et al., 2022). When it comes to the mental health impact, literature tells a mixed story, while some (Freire et al., 2023; Jiménez-Muro et al., 2025) argue that there is no relationship between dating app use and mental health, other research (Sharabi et al., 2026) highlights that for users who had higher symptoms of depression, loneliness, and anxiety, they experienced worsening emotional exhaustion.

Literature that focuses on just the use of dating apps (Freire et al., 2023; Jiménez-Muro et al., 2025) tend to conclude that use of dating apps does not have any negative effects on mental health, however, in 2026, Sharabi et al. argues that there is very little longitudinal research when

it comes to well-being of dating apps users and they argue that dating app users tend to experience burnout over time leading to emotional exhaustion and inefficacy over time (Sharabi et al., 2026). Along with a focus on the number of profile swipes and time spent on dating apps per day, there also seems to be a space for more longitudinal studies that focus on how users' enthusiasm and engagement with dating apps change over time.

2.3 Harm and reporting

The existence of negative feelings about dating apps and the effect on the well-being of users can also be shaped by the harm they have experienced via dating apps. According to Bates et al., (2023), in a survey conducted among 217 adults living in the UK and the Republic of Ireland, 60.4% of the respondents reported being sent harassing or offensive messages that were sexual in nature, and 41.9% stated having been catfished. A further 43.8% reported that someone tried to pressure them to send sexually explicit pictures. Similarly, another research study undertaken in Hong Kong in 2016 shows that dating app users were more likely to be sexually abused than non-users (Choi et al., 2018). Similarly, in the case of the US, a study by Echevarria et al. (2023) among 277 college students found that 88.4% of participants self-reported that they had experienced at least one instance of dating-app facilitated sexual violence. In 2024, a comprehensive study done by Gewirtz-Meydan et al. (2024) found across twelve studies that women and individuals identifying as other sexual minorities are at higher risk of sexual harassment in dating apps, and those experiences are associated with higher levels of depression, anxiety, loneliness, and lower self-esteem.

Even though there is an abundance of literature that looks at the prevalence of harms experienced via dating apps and the different kinds of harm, there is limited research that focuses on what actions the user takes in the apps after an experience with harm. A research report published by the Australian Government in 2022 about sexual harassment, aggression, and violence victimization among mobile dating app and website users in Australia reported that half of the respondents, who were subjected to online or in-person dating app-facilitated sexual violence, were blocked or unmatched by the perpetrator, or the perpetrator deleted their own account afterwards (Wolbers et al., 2022).

In Match Group's Safe Dating Report for Australia 2025, which covered the activity from 1 July 2024 to 30 June 2025 (Match Group, 2025), the company reported that they banned 662,112 accounts but not all the accounts are unique, as some of the accounts are double-counted if they attempt to create a new account after a previous ban. Another Australian report on Reporting of dating app facilitated sexual violence to the police mentions that 44.5% of respondents have experienced online or in-person sexual abuse that is facilitated by a dating app, and 21.5% report it to an online dating platform (Lawler & Boxall, 2023). Though I could not find a similar report for the US, this report does highlight that accounts are getting reported and even proactively banned on platforms.

However, there seems to be a gap in understanding about the dynamic between the platform and users to mitigate that harm. In 2021, Match Group released the "Are you sure?" feature on Tinder, which provides a warning in real-time to users about their opening line. According to the company, by 2023, 500 million messages had been either edited or deleted by users after the

feature triggered to flag potentially harassing or problematic language (Match Group, 2023).

This is a more proactive approach from the platform's side. However, there is a lack of literature that explores what actions users take within the apps after facing harm.

2.4 Rationalization of harm

In 2016, Shaw discussed the Instagram page [Bye Felipe](#), where people submit screenshots of examples of harassment and sexual entitlement they faced from men on dating apps (Shaw, 2016). The creator of the page believes that this page takes away the power of those insults by using humor (Shaw, 2016; Tweten, 2014). Use of humor as resistance is not limited to Bye Felipe; other pages like [Instagranniepants](#), whose bio reads “Objectifying men who objectify women in 3 easy steps: Man sends crude line via internet. Draw him naked. Send portrait to lucky man, enjoy results.” also use art to fight against harassment faced by women in dating apps. Shaw mentioned a 2015 New York Times article that mentions how users resorted to public shaming of profiles because they believe blocking is ineffective, as the harasser can resurface on the platform with a new profile (Krueger, 2015; Shaw, 2016).

Similarly, in 2023, Gillett published a paper in which an interviewee said she did not report the experience of intrusion to the platform because she did not want to “overreact”. Gillett mentions how women do safety work, like looking up matched users in other platforms to check for cross-platform convergence, not linking their social media accounts to dating profiles, and looking for red flags during interactions to keep themselves safe. This harm prevention mechanism is rationalized and normalized to such an extent that they don't consider it as additional labor (Gillett, 2023; Pruchniewska, 2020).

On one hand, as users face harm on the platform, they use different safety measures to take matters into their own hands: using humor to resist harm, and framing abuse as a joke or humor can also normalize abuse on dating apps (Gillett, 2018; Jane, 2017). On the other hand, rationalization is also happening on the other side, among those with discriminatory behaviors, who justify their actions as a preference (Conner, 2023).

2.5 Illusion of control

The datafication of intimacy and an algorithmic approach to finding relationships give users a sense of credibility and safety by creating a selective barrier that makes users feel like they have control (De Ridder, 2022). *Illusion of control* is a psychological phenomenon where people are confident about their ability to influence the outcome of a chance-based event (De Ridder, 2022; Langer, 1975). As the literature mentions, people often think of online dating as a chance-based event (Huang et al., 2022); it makes sense that people would want to maintain some control over this process (De Ridder, 2022). A study run by Tong et al. in 2016 suggests that systems that blend the see-and-screen format with algorithmic suggestion can produce an additive effect that boosts the feeling of agency in users (Tong et al., 2016). It provides a dual benefit of control and algorithmic validation during the mate selection process (Tong et al., 2016). Though the presence of algorithms and see-and-screen functionality can give users the feeling of agency, according to research published by Langlais and Lee in 2025, it seems like young adults might not view mobile dating apps as helpful for forming relationships (Langlais & Lee, 2025). While some users believe that providing more information to the algorithm will help it narrow down the pool

for them (Huang et al., 2022), others believe that there is a conflict of interest between the promise of dating apps and their commercial interest, so they deploy actions like manipulating their profile by adding more photos, expanding filters, creating fake accounts of the opposite gender to see their competition, all in the attempt to regain control of their profile visibility in the hope of getting more recommendations (Alizadeh et al., 2024).

The use of Reddit to get feedback on dating app profiles is another way users try to achieve success in dating platforms by improving their self-presentation, and was discussed by Sobieraj and Humphreys in 2021, where out of 255 posts they examined in r/Tinder, 83.5% of them were posts with people requesting feedback on their dating profiles (Sobieraj & Humphreys, 2022).

2.6 Continued engagement and multiple motivations to use dating apps

Although dating apps are marketed as a place to find romantic connections, the literature suggests that users engage in dating apps for a variety of other non-romantic reasons, too. Apart from finding something romantic, users have varied reasons for using dating apps, such as fun, easing boredom, self-worth validation, and ease of communication (Sobieraj & Humphreys, 2022; Couch & Liamputtong, 2008). A 2024 study amongst Korean Tinder users found that some users first used the platform with no intention to form relationships, rather to relieve stress and depression, simply because it is fun, while another participant who used the platform for entertainment acknowledged the addictive aspect of the platform (Kim et al., 2024). In 2023, Vera Cruz et al. found that 65.3% of Tinder users were either married or in a relationship (Vera Cruz et al., 2023), suggesting that dating apps use frequency goes beyond the pursuit of romantic relationships.

Though most of the diverse usage of the platforms stems from the users' side, literature also suggests that platforms like Tinder are gamified in a way that incentivizes users to gather matches instead of pursuing meaningful connections (Nader, 2025). Lurkers, users who view the content of a platform without engaging with it (Liu et al., 2024), are well-researched in the context of social media (Liu et al., 2024). Literature suggests that fatigue and anxiety play a role in lurking behavior (Liu et al., 2024), and lurkers also believe that their emotional needs will not be satisfied if they post (Rau et al., 2008). However, in the context of online dating, there is a gap in the literature regarding passive engagement on the platform without initiating conversations. Some literature discusses harm experienced by people on dating platforms (Bates et al., 2023, Choi et al., 2018, Echevarria et al., 2023, Gewirtz-Meydan et al., 2024), however, as dating apps have replaced other traditional ways of meeting partners (Rosenfeld et al., 2019), studying lurking in dating apps to know what kind of people are in the market without actively interacting with others, thus reducing harm exposure, could be a potential user behavior, which needs more research.

When taken together, these different strands of literature show that the use of dating apps is not a straightforward process, where users sign up, swipe, go on dates, and find love. Rather, it is a complex experience shaped by multiple mental maps of the platform, positive and negative responses to being part of the platform, safety concerns, and users' continued engagement despite dissatisfaction or harm. Existing literature helps us explain different parts of the user experience process with dating apps, including why they join, how they feel when they are on the platforms, what kind of negative experiences they face, and how they make sense of negative experiences.

However, these themes are often studied in isolation, which makes it difficult to study the tension between conflicting emotions users experience as part of being on the platforms. This study builds on prior work by examining how users conceptualize dating apps across different dimensions, offering a more holistic account of how people conceptualize dating apps, their experience on the platform, and what keeps them on the platform.

3. Methods

3.1 Data Collection

3.1.1 Survey

The survey was conducted among Cornell students through convenience sampling. The survey was created in Qualtrics and posted in the Sona system with assistance from the Cornell Business Simulation Lab. The survey had 85 total questions, which were a mix of Likert questions and open-ended text questions. The survey was IRB-approved (IRB #0150225). The students could fill out the survey to receive extra credit for approved classes. In total, 195 responses were received. Out of those, 20 had never used dating apps, so their responses were excluded from the study. They were filtered with a question about their dating app usage at the beginning of the survey.

Of the 175 students, 133 optionally submitted their age. The sample skews young, with 65% of the participants falling between 18 and 21. 22% of the participants identified themselves as 25 or older, which represents some graduate students and other non-traditional students. As per the gender distribution, 167 respondents submitted their gender, among which, 54.49% (n = 91)

identified as female, 44.9% (n = 75) identified as male, and only 1 participant identified as non-binary.

3.1.2 Reddit

Based on an exploration of different dating subreddits, ten were chosen for research (as measured by number of members and recent activity). They were: dating_advice, OnlineDating, hingeapp, Tinder, OnlineDatingApps, dating, DatingHell, online_dating_advice, FemaleDatingStrategy, longtermDATING. The subreddits were scraped using the standard Reddit API and PRAW. The data were scraped in December 2025. Since Reddit has limits on how much data can be scraped and how far back in time it can be accessed, 5,833 posts were scraped, and the timeline ranged from August to December, 2025. Among those 5,833 posts, 1436 posts only had pictures in the post, so they were excluded from any textual analysis. However, flairs, a tag on a post that categorizes its content like: venting, Need Help, profile review, and the subreddit they were posted on, were still taken into consideration for distribution analysis. To respect the privacy of Reddit users, the study does not explicitly quote any Reddit posts with participants' usernames. This privacy consideration was also mentioned in the IRB submission.

3.2 Data Analysis

The study focused on the overall experience of using dating apps for users in surveys and Reddit by looking at the responses both qualitatively and quantitatively.

3.2.1 Survey

Qualitative analysis focused on users' responses to open-ended questions, for example, what kind of metaphors they would use to describe online dating, and the good and bad aspects of dating platforms. Quantitative analysis focused on Likert-style questions around users' experience with apps, users' safety experience with the app, and user agency. The goal was to examine how users describe their experience in direct questions, focusing on user experience, safety, and agency, and in more indirect questions, such as metaphors, and to observe if there are any gaps or inconsistencies.

Metaphor classification followed a three-step hierarchical coding scheme that was created after reading the survey responses. First, the responses were classified into granular concept categories like browsing, puzzle, luck, scary, etc. Those concepts were then categorized into higher-level themes like passive, waiting, search discovery, and labor effort. And finally, these higher-level themes were classified into 4 dominant themes: negative, game/chance, market, and labor, in that priority order, respectively. If a metaphor has negative emotion and market-related keywords, then it would be classified as negative. This priority was based on the most distinctive themes among the four. The extensive keyword match is attached in the Appendix.

For Likert questions, a 7-point Likert scale was used with options including strongly disagree, disagree, somewhat disagree, neither agree nor disagree, agree, somewhat agree, and strongly agree. In the process of data cleaning, strongly agree and somewhat agree were changed into agree, and the same was done for disagree. The study focused on general agreement or disagreement with the statements over the degree of agreement or disagreement. The study

reports the mean, total distribution of Likert-style questions, and the difference between opinions based on gender.

Responses to the open-ended question on what dating apps do right were analyzed using a keyword-based classification approach. Based on presence of predefined keywords, responses were grouped into four themes: Algorithm, Safety, Validation, and Access. Each response was assigned to the theme with the strongest keyword match, and ties were resolved using a fixed priority order: Algorithm first, followed by Safety, Validation, and Access. The full keyword table is included in the Appendix.

3.2.2 Reddit

For Reddit, the goal was to distill the vast Reddit data into the themes visible in the survey. Quantitative analysis of Reddit data focused on keyword-based tagging for how long users have been on the platform, and if they are returning users, and performing sentiment analysis to see the longitudinal changes in user experience over time. The platform duration was captured using rule-based keyword matching and applied using regular expressions. The posts were divided into 5 categories: early users (active for less than 30 days), users who have been on the platform for a few months (30-364 days), users who have been on the platform for at least a year (365+ days), returning users, and no reference to time for posts that did not match any regex. This method has some limitations, as it depends on the user explicitly mentioning how long they have been on the platform; it is not always accurate because some posts have a timeline mentioning either how long they have been single or their relationship duration, which could be mistaken for platform

duration. This is mostly for approximation and should be interpreted with caution. The extensive keyword match is attached in the Appendix.

For the sentiment analysis of the tagged posts, three different sentiment analysis techniques were used: predefined keyword matching, VADER sentiment analysis, and GoEmotions. For keyword matching, a set of negative stems was manually created based on recurring language observed in dating app-related discourse. It included terms that reflect emotional exhaustion (e.g., exhaust, drain, hopeless), moral judgments (e.g., fake, misleading, shallow), and frustration (suck, awful, soul-crush). Stem matching, rather than an exact word match, was used to capture different morphological variations. For example: frustrat captures frustrated, frustrating, frustration. If a post consists of one or more of these stems, it was flagged as negative. The extensive list of keywords is attached in the Appendix.

Similarly, VADER (Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Analysis) produces a score from -1 (most negative) to +1 (most positive) by evaluating the intensity of the words and their polarity. It accounts for modifiers like capitalization, punctuation, and negation. Any posts that scored below -0.05 were classified as negative (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014). However, VADER usually has a hard time with sarcasm and irony (Miller, n.d.). Finally, GoEmotions is a fine-tuned RoBERTa model that is trained on Reddit comments, and it was used to capture more granular emotional categories rather than simple positive and negative polarity (Demszky et al., 2020). It classifies text into 27 different emotional categories (Demszky et al., 2020), and among them, anger, annoyance, disappointment, disapproval, disgust, embarrassment, fear, grief, nervousness, remorse, and sadness were used as negative sentiments in this project. Since GoEmotions is

trained on Reddit data, it is better suited to handle the informal community-based language patterns seen in the corpus.

Using these three methods together offers a complementary perspective as keyword matching makes it interpretable, VADER gives baseline context, and GoEmotions adds more emotional granularity. Triangulating across all three methods allows for a more robust negative sentiment analysis than using just one method.

Qualitative analysis involved examining posts about reporting and safety incidents on dating apps to understand how people use the online community to enhance their online dating experience. This included manually searching for posts that mention reporting, examining, and classifying if they are talking about being reported, reporting someone, or considering reporting someone.

4. Results

This study draws on data from surveys and Reddit posts to answer how users conceptualize online dating and how they navigate issues around safety on dating platforms.

4.1 Conceptualization of dating apps using metaphors in the age of AI

A 2018 study found that 53% of American users admit to lying on their dating profile (Schwartz & Velotta, 2018), so users are already dealing with questions of authenticity in dating apps. From the 7-scale Likert-style questions, the results were categorized as agree, disagree, and neutral.

44% of 172 respondents agree that other people's answers to prompts feel AI-generated; however, only 19% agree to have used AI to answer prompts. This agreement further reduces to 11% when asked if they use AI to start a conversation, and 5% when asked if they use AI to judge pictures they post. This self-exemption pattern, where users think others are using AI but not them, provides useful context when we talk about the metaphors they use to describe their experiences and the different strategies they use to navigate the online dating landscape.

Out of the 175 total participants, 134 of them optionally answered the question of what metaphor they would use to describe online dating. Using the three-step hierarchical coding scheme described in 3.2.1, metaphors were divided into 4 dominant categories: market, labor, game/chance, and negative. A residual category, none, was used for descriptions that didn't match any themes. As shown in Figure 1, the most common theme was market (n=34, 25.37%), followed by labor (n=32, 23.88%), game/chance (n=31, 23.13%), negative (n=23, 17.16%), and none (n=14, 10.44%). Figure 2 shows the word cloud of raw responses for each category, illustrating the most frequently used terms across each of them.

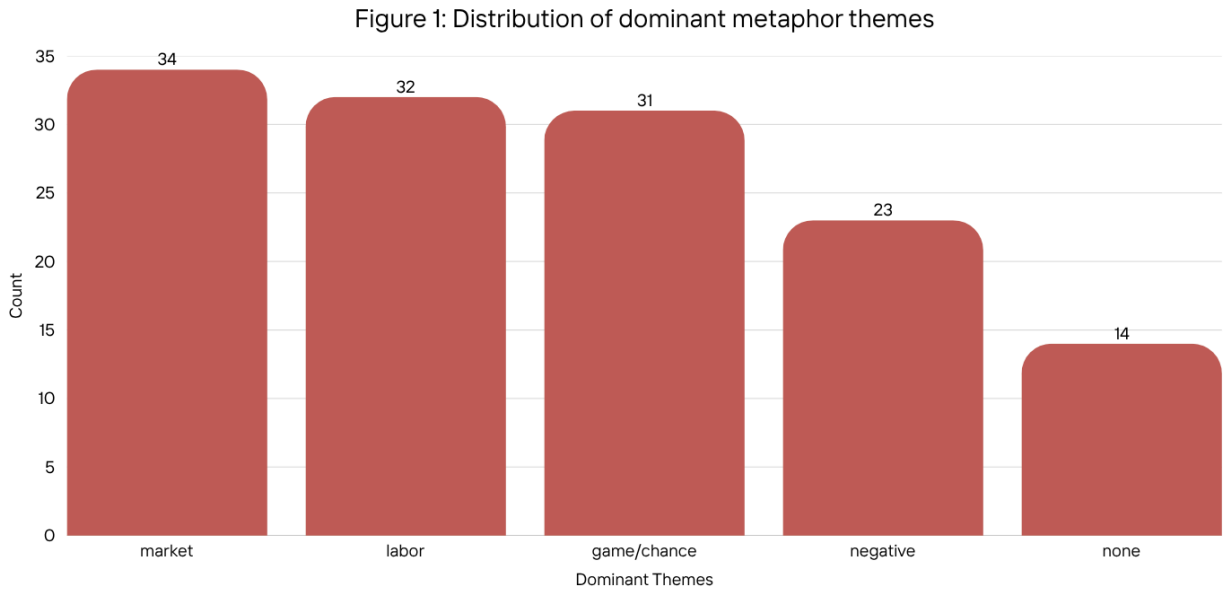
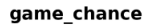


Figure 1: Distribution of dominant metaphor themes

market



Length of use	Game/Chance	Labor	Market	Negative	Total
< 1 month	8 (24.2%)	7 (21.2%)	11 (33.3%)	7 (21.2%)	33
1 to 3 months	8 (24.2%)	11 (33.3%)	11 (33.3%)	3 (9.1%)	33
3 to 6 months	4 (22.2%)	4 (22.2%)	6 (33.3%)	4 (22.2%)	18
6 months to < 1 year	0 (0.0%)	2 (33.3%)	1 (16.7%)	3 (50.0%)	6
1 to 2 years	2 (16.7%)	6 (50.0%)	1 (8.3%)	3 (25.0%)	12
> 2 years	8 (53.3%)	2 (13.3%)	2 (13.3%)	3 (20.0%)	15
Blank	1 (33.3%)	0 (0.0%)	2 (66.7%)	0 (0.0%)	3
Total	31	32	34	23	120

Table 1: Distribution of metaphor dominant theme across the length of platform use.

Since the distribution of the total number of participants across the length of platform use is inconsistent, the number of metaphors in each theme across each length follows the same inconsistency. However, we can see that earlier users tend to use market and game/chance metaphor, but the 6-month to < 1-year user mark tends to use negative metaphor, and labor in the 1 to 2 years mark, and again negative metaphor for users who have been on the platform for more than 2 years.

The sentiment difference even within the same theme is clearer when looking at metaphor examples:

For the market as a dominant theme:

20 Male, Length of use: Undisclosed

Online dating is like rummaging through a giant, slightly chaotic thrift store for feelings.

You scroll past most “options,” try a few on that look good on the hanger, and realize some fit way better or worse than you expected. It’s tiring and hit-or-miss.

20 Female, Length of use: 3 to 6 months

Sort of like browsing a bookstore for a book you like

While both of these metaphors fall under the market theme, they create two very different kinds of mental images.

And this pattern emerges in other themes as well. For example, if we look at the negative theme among new users and old users:

19 Male, Length of use: <1 month

It's like taking a multiple choice test when you're really tired. Half the time you're circling answers and hoping you pick the right one. And a week later, you find out you either completely bombed it or got a perfect score.

22 Female, Length of use: <1 month

swamp, because you will meet all kinds of people no matter good or bad

Age undisclosed Female, Length of use: >2 years

A boot stamping on a human face—forever.

25+ Male, Length of use: >2 years

A programmed reflection of the world's injustices.

Similarly, for the labor-dominant theme, the pattern is still consistent.

19 Male, Length of use: <1 month

Online dating is like scrolling through trailers instead of watching the full movie. You get highlights, carefully edited moments, and perfect angles, but you only learn what it's really about once you commit to pressing "play."

25+ Male, Length of use: 1 to 2 years

If you're a guy, it's like trying to find water in the barest, driest desert you can possibly imagine, or, equivalently, trying to find breathable oxygen in space.

The intensity of feelings and the mental image of these feelings, even within the same dominant theme, is very different for users of different genders and lengths of platform use.

4.2 Experiencing Harms on Dating platforms

The survey asked participants which of the following harms they had experienced on any dating platform. It had the following options: unwanted sexual messages, identity misrepresentation/catfishing, coercion/pressure, doxing/stalking, hate speech/slurs, non-consensual sharing of images, and in-person safety incidents, and others. There was a text entry attached with others where they can explain other harms they have faced. 52% of all participants (91 out of 175) said they have experienced at least one of the harms on dating apps.

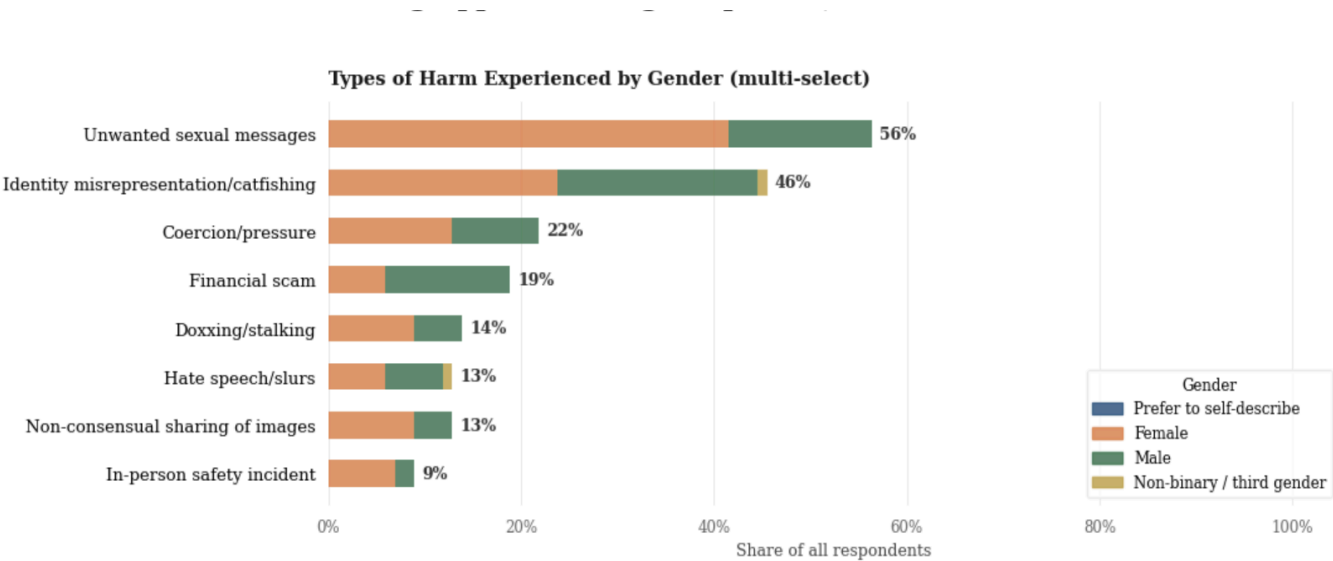


Figure 3: Types of Harm Experienced by Gender

As shown in Figure 3, 56% of all participants have dealt with unwanted sexual messages, followed by identity misrepresentation at 46%. Similarly, in-person safety incidents are the lowest at 9%. However, across all kinds of harms, it is more commonly experienced by female users.

Additionally, a female queer user writes, *“just to elaborate on the in-person safety incident because this story is wild; one time I went on a hinge date to grab drinks and after a few rounds found out that the date had brought a gun.”*

Similarly, users were also asked if they have encountered bias related to race/ethnicity, body, disability, or gender/sexuality in dating apps. And, 25% of the participants optionally responded yes.

Despite the prevalence of these experiences, reporting remains largely absent. Of all participants who have experienced harm, 71% of users have never reported an incident on dating apps. Figure 4 shows, in more detail, the reporting frequency of users who have experienced harm.

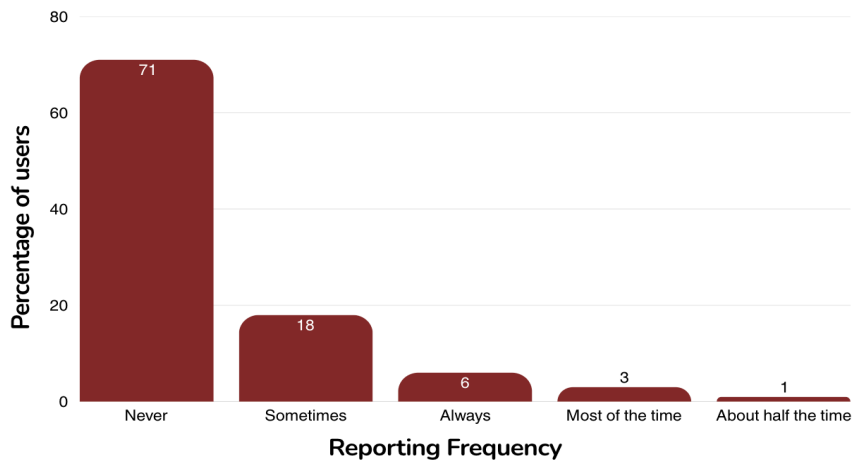


Figure 4: Reporting frequency of harms experienced in dating apps

As shown in Figure 4, even though users have experienced multiple harms in their online dating experience, a vast majority of those users do not report those harms to the platforms.

4.3 Rationalization of harm

Beyond the questions around experiencing harm in dating apps, the survey also explored how participants perceive safety and emotional well-being on dating apps through a series of 7-point Likert-style questions.

To understand user safety perception on dating apps, participants were asked to state agreement or disagreement with: “I feel safe using dating apps” and “I feel safe meeting people I meet on dating apps.” These items together capture both the in-app experience of safety and perceived risk in a real-world setting.

I feel safe using dating apps.

Disagree Neutral Agree

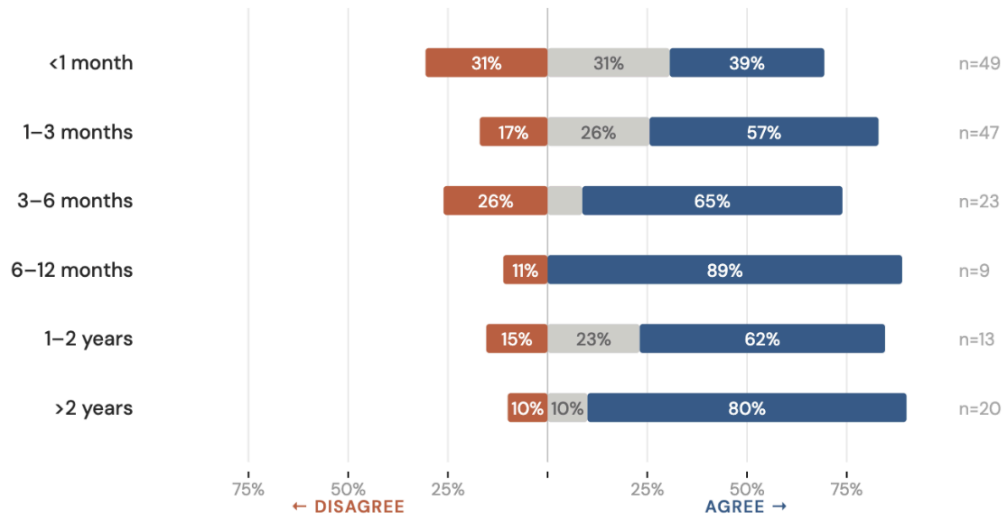


Figure 5: Percentage of user agreement and disagreement with the in-app safety perception statement across the duration of dating app use

I feel safe meeting people I meet on a dating app.

Disagree Neutral Agree

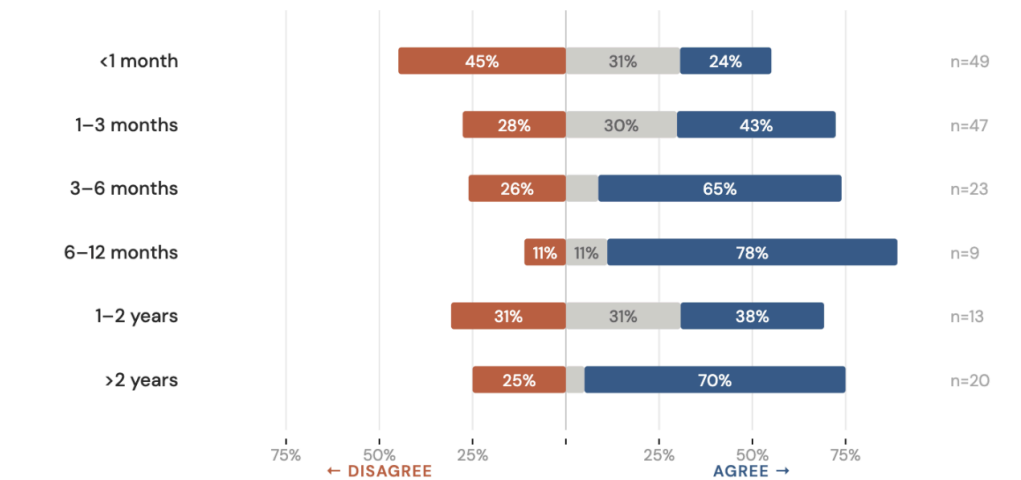


Figure 6: Percentage of user agreement and disagreement with the in-person safety perception statement across the duration of dating app use

Figures 5 and 6 show a noticeable shift in perceived safety across the duration of use. Among the users who have been on the platform for less than a month, 39% agreed with the statement regarding in-app safety perception, and 31% disagreed. In contrast, among users with more than 2 years of experience, 80% agreed with the in-app safety statement and only 10% disagreed with it. Similarly, for in-person safety perception, 45% of users with less than one month of experience disagree with the statement, while only 24% agreed. Compare that with users with more than 2 years of experience, 25% disagreed with the statement, but 70% agreed. This suggests that perceived safety tends to increase with familiarity with the platform. However, these results need to be interpreted with caution because the sample size of short-term users is nearly twice that of the long-term user group, which may affect comparability between the groups.

Alongside safety, the survey also focused on positive and negative emotions associated with dating apps. Participants also responded to “Apps feel like a chore” and “Apps increase enjoyment.” These sentences intentionally contrast each other to observe how participants respond to them.

Apps increase enjoyment

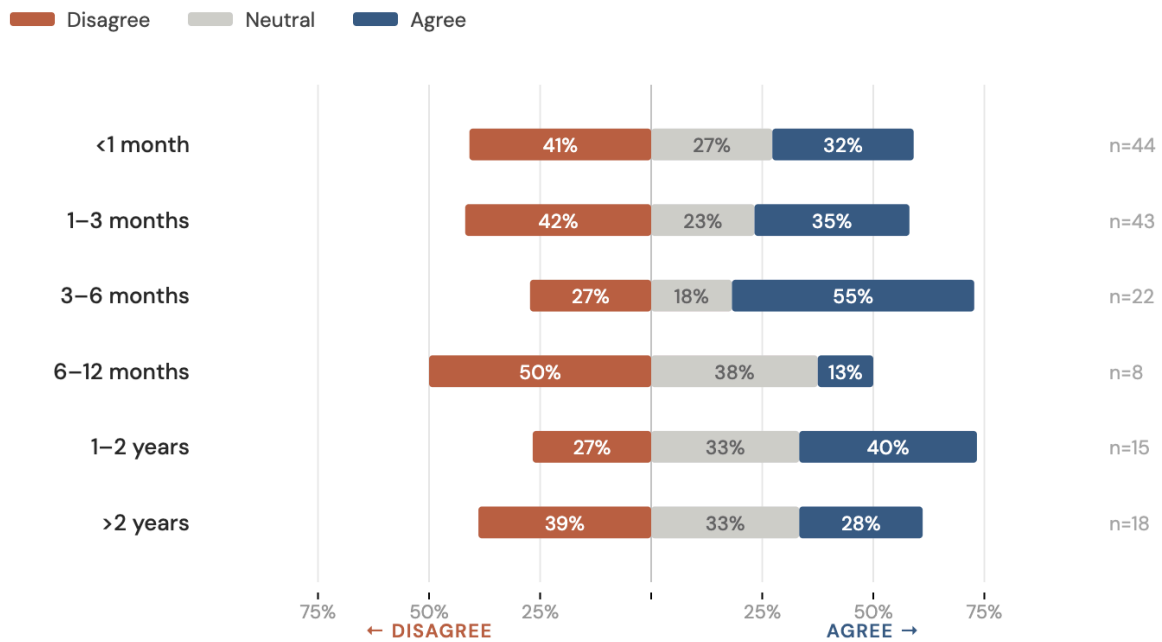


Figure 7: Percentage of user agreement and disagreement with the app enjoyment statement across the duration of dating app use

Apps feel like a chore

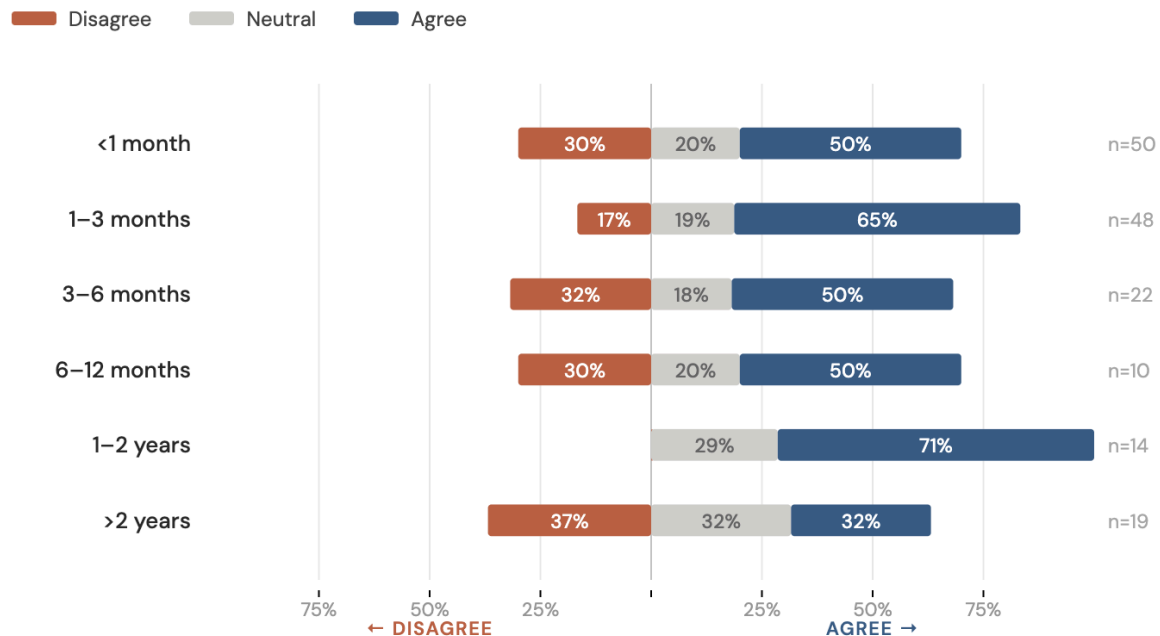


Figure 8: Percentage of user agreement and disagreement with the "apps feel like a chore" statement across the duration of dating app use

Figures 7 and 8 show a complex and contradictory relationship between duration of use and user experience. In terms of enjoyment, agreement peaked among users in the 3-6 months range (55%), but declined sharply at 6-12 months (13%), and even among long-term users (>2 years), disagreement remains at 39%. The number of users in different duration groups is not the same across these questions because the questions were optional, and some users did not respond to some questions.

Similarly, the question that asked whether ‘apps feel like a chore’ told another interesting story. Agreement to the statement that “Apps feel like a chore” remained consistently high across all duration groups, but peaked among 1-2 year users (71%). Among the > 2-year user group, agreement that apps increase enjoyment dropped to 28%, and agreement that apps feel like a chore also stands at 32%, which is the lowest among all user groups. It seems like these users are neither burdened by dating apps nor particularly satisfied. This aligns with the idea of rationalization of harm, where long-term users tend to recalibrate their standards over time rather than discontinuing app usage.

Rationalization of harm shows up in interesting ways in the Reddit data as well. Out of 4,395 total Reddit posts, only 6 explicitly mentioned reporting another user. It is a strikingly low figure, which itself suggests a reluctance to formally act on negative experiences. Of those posts, two of them ask, “Did I do the right thing by reporting them?”, indicating a form of seeking external validation and uncertainty and self-doubt even after taking action. Other posts with the mention of reporting include confused expressions about being banned by the platform without explanation, expressing confusion at platform-level decisions. One account involved being catfished on a date and getting reported by the perpetrator. Interestingly, posts mentioning reporting someone else were considerably longer than average, marked by extensive justification and detailed documentation of observed behavioral patterns to justify the reporting.

The nature of these posts suggests that users often felt compelled to build a case before considering reporting. These patterns point to a tendency to tolerate and internalise harmful interactions rather than escalating them through formal platform mechanisms. This further supports the rationalization of harm framework established by survey findings.

4.4 Illusion of control

To better understand what drives this rationalization, the survey tried to understand whether users believed their actions defined their experience on dating platforms, using the statement “I believe my action (prompts, pictures, timing) noticeably changes my matching outcomes.” and testing the consistency of the agency implied by the above statement by analysing the presence of user agency in metaphor framing and other Likert-style questions like “I believe I know my way around making the algorithm work for me.”

I believe my actions (prompts, photos, timing) noticeably change my matching outcomes.

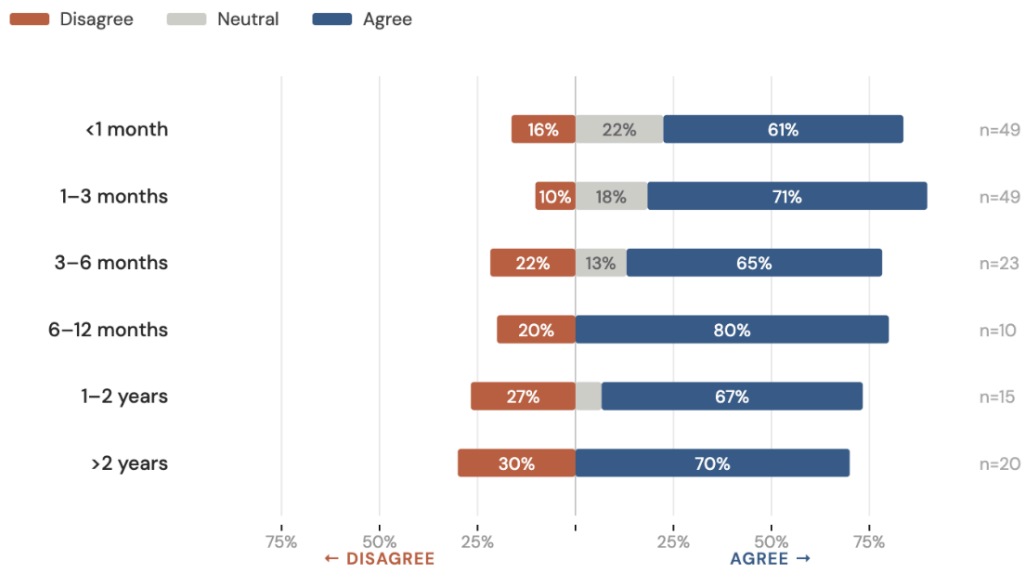


Figure 9: Percentage of user agreement and disagreement with the user action defining experience statement across the duration of dating app use

I believe I know my way around making the algorithm work for me.

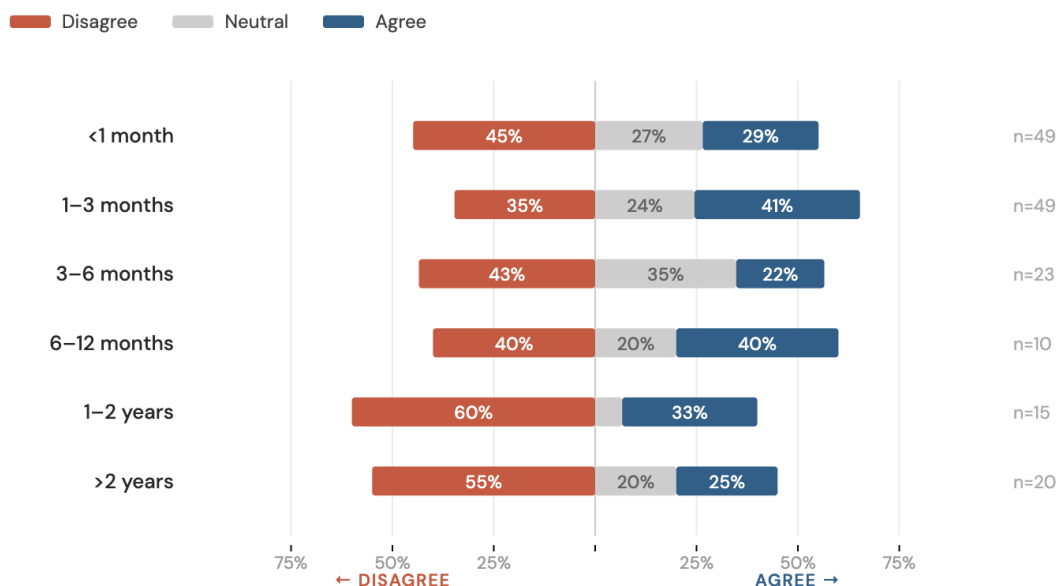


Figure 10: Percentage of user agreement and disagreement with the user perception of their familiarity with making the algorithm work in their favor

Figure 9 shows that users across all duration groups mostly agree that their action noticeably changes their matching outcomes. This pattern of agreement remains relatively consistent regardless of how long users have been on the platforms, suggesting that a sense of personal agency in the matching process is a stable belief among dating app users, and it is not eroding with experience. This perception of control is important in the context of rationalization of harm because if users think their outcomes on platforms are directly shaped by their own behavior, they might be more inclined to associate negative experiences like harassment or poor matching outcomes with their own actions rather than the platform. This internalization can also discourage users from reporting because they feel some degree of responsibility for the situation they find themselves in.

However, this sense of control has limits. Although users often believe that their prompts, pictures, and timing affect their outcomes, they are less confident that they understand how to make the algorithm work for them. Similarly, the metaphors were retagged using keyword search to examine if the same agency we saw in the Likert scale in Figure 9 would show up in the language users use to describe dating apps. Only 16 responses lean towards agency. This further strengthens the fact that when asked explicitly, users perceive that they have agency and control; the same sense of agency is not visible in descriptive and open-ended questions.

Examples of metaphor indicating user agency:

“What you put in is what you get out.”

“browsing Netflix”

Examples of metaphors indicating a lack of user agency:

“being a product on a shelf at the store.”

“Like gambling; highly dependent on luck.”

While the survey helps us capture what users explicitly believe about their agency, Reddit lets us capture more behavioral cues to understand their sense of agency. Users on Reddit display the illusion of control in a different way than the survey population. Their perceived sense of control shows up in profile review posts. A profile review post in Reddit is made by a dating app user who shares their full profile on a forum to get feedback from other Reddit users. The post

typically includes all elements of a dating profile, like photos, written bios, and answers to app-specific questions. Sometimes they also add some context about their situation, like how many matches they are getting, what they think is not working in their profile. The community then responds to those posts with honest and sometimes blunt critiques to help the original poster improve their chances on dating apps.

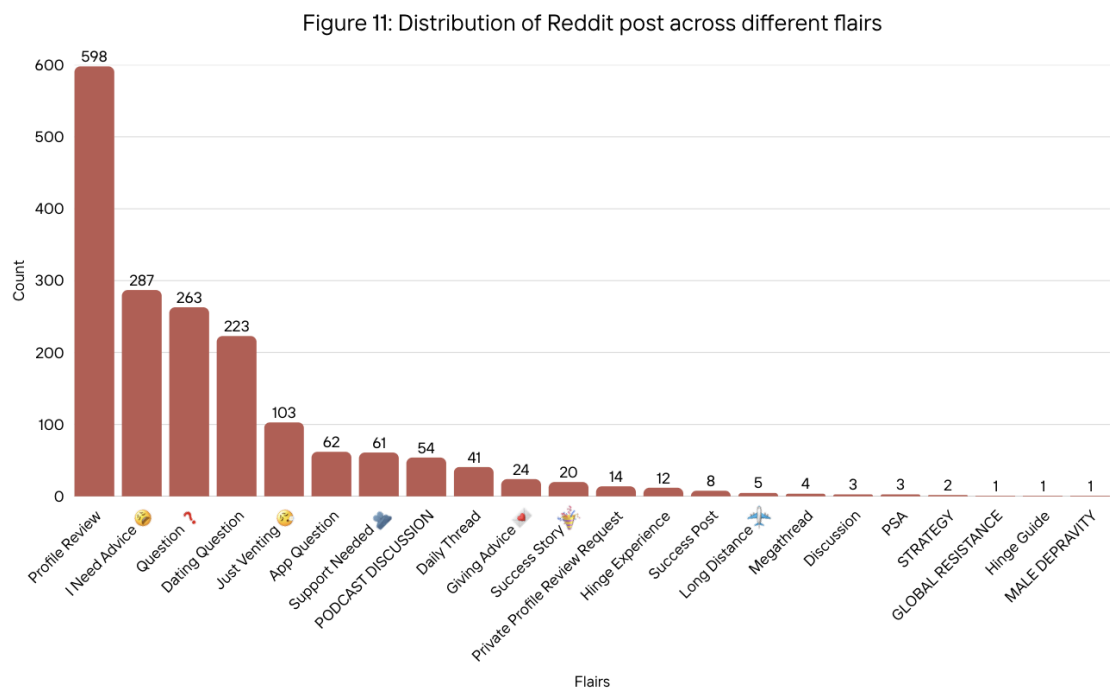


Figure 11: Distribution of Reddit posts across different flairs

Among the 5,833 total posts extracted, 1,790 had a flair tagged on it. Among those flairs, profile review accounts for 598 posts, private profile review accounts for 14 more, 34.18% (n = 612) of all tagged posts are profile review posts. Figure 11 shows the distribution of Reddit posts across different flairs, and profile reviews are the most common type of posts found in these 10 dating-related subreddits, followed by I Need Advice and Questions. This finding suggests that

users frequently turn to these communities to seek direct, peer-based evaluation of how they present themselves on dating platforms. The second and third most common flairs, being I Need Advice and Questions, further reinforce that these subreddits work as a support and feedback space for users.

Along with profile review, looking at Reddit posts qualitatively reveals some techniques people employ in the hope that it will improve their match quality, and also comes up with potential explanations on why it is not working out for them. For example, one user described how replacing a broadly relatable dating profile prompt with a more polarizing one reduced overall matches but attracted people who initiated plans quickly. Another user contemplates whether they should reach out to matches with failed conversations to figure out what went wrong. And, a few argue they are being shadowbanned by the platform in an attempt to explain why they are not getting any matches in 7-8 months.

Instead of questioning the opaque platform algorithm and design choices, users treat the platform as a meritocratic system that will reward the right profile, so they focus on refining their photos and prompts. And this creates a marketplace for other platforms that want to capitalize on this marketplace of hope, like profilehelper.com, which claims to be the leading online dating profile writing service in the US since 2005. Similarly with the rise of AI, newer platforms like agoodfirstdate.com are claiming to provide dating practice using AI/VR Date simulation. While users struggle to figure out why they are not succeeding in online dating, these kinds of platforms further add the onus on the user to think that they can control the outcome if only they pay extra and seek some help.

4.5 Continued Engagement

The user's tendency to self-correct, as seen by profile review, leads us to look at why users continue using the platform despite the prevalence of negative ways of framing their experience, as seen in the metaphors, and having experienced harm. This continued engagement with apps despite frustration indicates that the relationship between platforms and the users is complex and cannot be reduced to just satisfaction and dissatisfaction. To understand this better, we asked users how many dating apps they use, what they use each platform for, if they take a break from platforms, and what they think platforms are doing right. These questions together allow us to build a more nuanced understanding of users' continued engagement with the platform.

The survey asked the participants to pick all the dating platforms they have currently installed on their phone. 32% (n=56) of users use more than one platform, with most active users having up to 4 apps on their phone. Figure 12 displays the dating app usage among survey participants.

While popular apps like Hinge and Tinder dominate the space, some users also indicated using more niche apps like Amata, Tantan, Cerca, Hello Talk, Dil Mil, Intro, Feeld, Growlr, and Scruff.

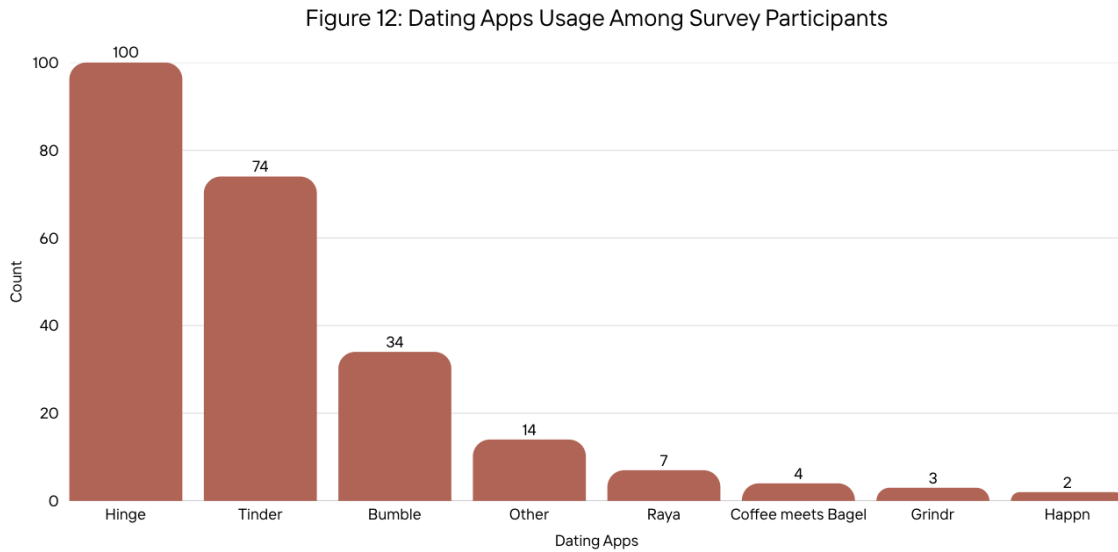


Figure 12: Dating Apps Usage Among Survey Participants

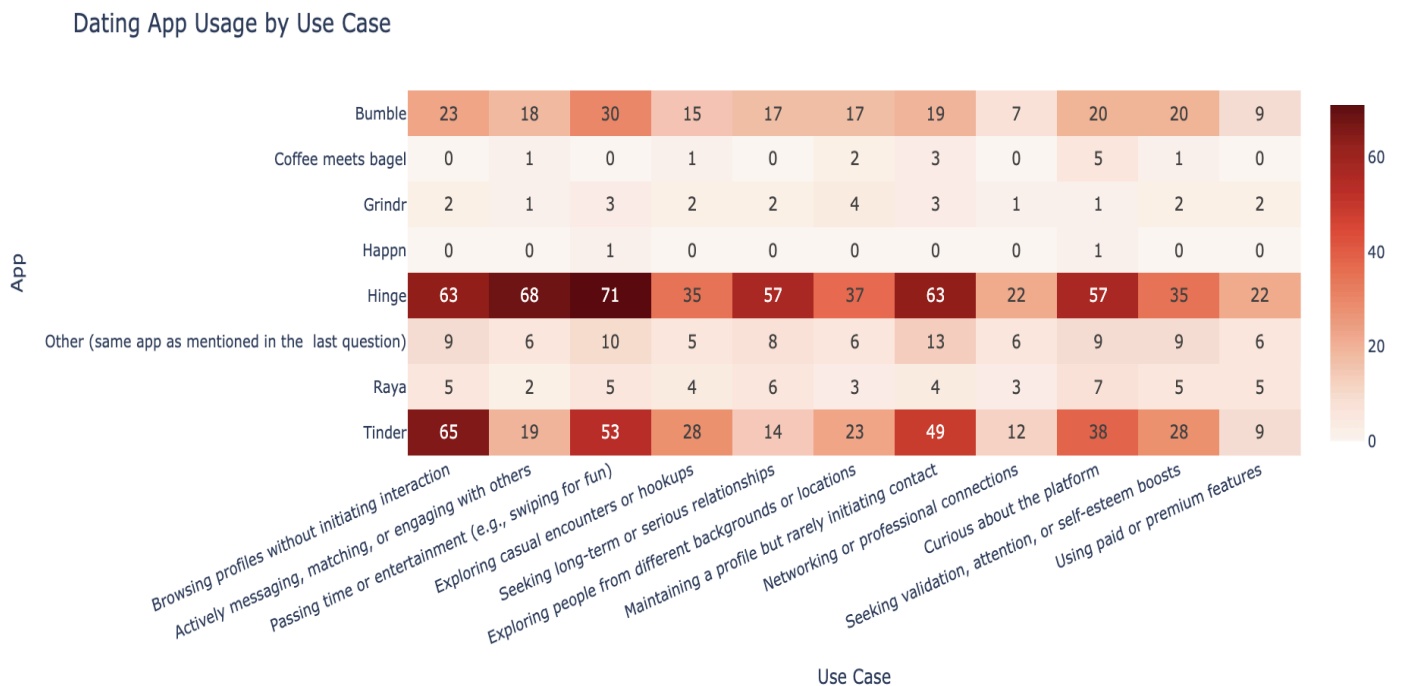


Figure 13: Dating App Usage by Use Case

While Figure 12 highlights the presence of multiple apps in a user's ecosystem, Figure 13 shows the variety of use cases for those apps by users that are not always about finding a partner or a date. Even though Hinge and Tinder are the dominant platforms for most use cases, the fact that users use the platform for these diverse use cases, from exploring their curiosity about the platform, self-validation, to even using it for networking or professional connections, provides important context on why users continue engaging despite having a bad experience. This suggests that user retention on dating platforms can sometimes also be driven by some unintentional purpose that the platform serves for users.

However, this presence of varied use cases does not mean that experiencing harm on the platform does not affect the user in any way. The survey asked the participants if they had taken a break from dating apps in the past 6 months, and 156 participants optionally replied to the question, and 83% (n=130) agreed that they had taken a break from the platform in the last 6 months. Though the survey did not define what taking a break would mean, it can be uninstalling the app, deleting their profile, or not using the app for a few days, 83% saying they have taken a break suggest that engaging with dating apps for a long period of time carries an emotional cost that periodically becomes too high to bear.

To further understand how this cost accumulates and intensifies, we turn to Reddit, where we can examine users' experiences in real time and across different stages of being on the platform. By classifying users into early users, a few months, 1+year, returning, and no reference to time

based on keyword matching, explained in 3.2.2, we triangulate the presence of negative emotions using keyword regex search, VADER sentiment analysis, and GoEmotions(RoBERTa).

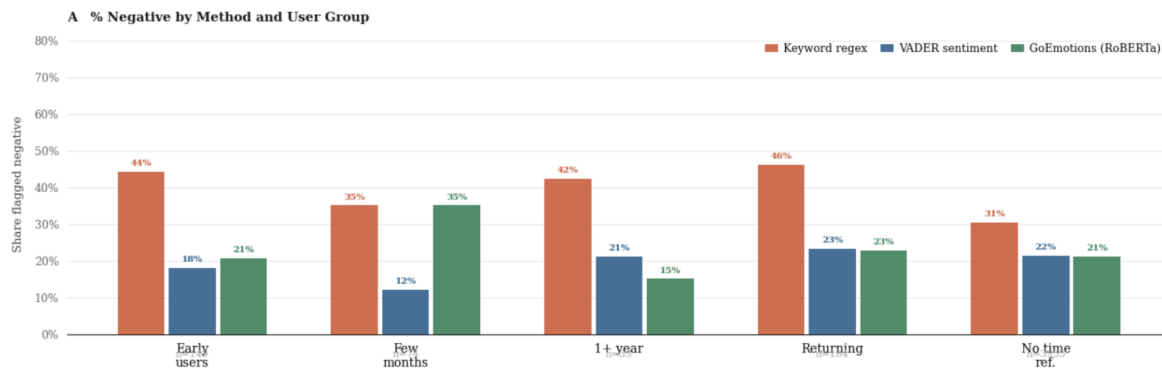


Figure 14: Negative emotions by Method and User Group

Figure 14 shows the triangulation of negative sentiment on users across different time groups. Compared to VADER and GoEmotions, keyword regex shows the highest negative sentiment across all timelines because keyword search often misses the contextual nuances of natural language. VADER and GoEmotions produce more conservative sentiment estimates. These three methods do not always converge in a direction, especially in the ‘few months’ group, where GoEmotions peaks but VADER reports the lowest score; similar inconsistency is seen in the 1+year mark as well, where GoEmotions drops again. The inconsistency across the different methods is reflective of the inherent difficulty of sentiment classification in dating app discourses because the language is often ambiguous, users tend to connect multiple stories across multiple timelines and emotions, making it difficult to parse the nuances. Despite these inconsistencies, one pattern that is relatively consistent across all three methods is that returning users tend to

experience higher negative sentiments, hinting that re-engagement with dating apps might be associated with increased frustrations.

This finding brings us back to the survey, which contextualizes why users return despite the cost. When we asked participants what they think is the one thing that dating apps do right, 149 participants optionally answered the question, out of which 72.5% ($n = 108$) used access-related keywords to answer the question. The keyword classification is explained in 3.2.1.

Together, these questions illustrate that even though a negative experience leaves a mark on users, users may remain on the apps partly for more expected purposes, like access, and partly for some unexpected purposes, like professional connection. This tension between harm and continued engagement is important to explore to understand user engagement on these platforms.

5. Discussion

This study aimed to understand how users make sense of dating apps and how they deal with different experiences on the apps. Across survey data and Reddit discourse, a consistent pattern emerged: users experience harm, they rationalize it, and continue engaging with the platform. Unlike key themes mentioned in earlier literature, the continued engagement is not just because of access, but also an illusion of control that is sustained by the platform and other players around. While existing literature has documented harm and access separately, this study bridges these two concepts, explaining the critical role played by users' illusion of control.

Users' views about dating apps and their ways of navigating the ecosystem are a journey, and as Sharabi et al. (2026) highlighted, there is a lack of a longitudinal study of this journey. This study suggests that the journey is cyclical and sheds light on some of the pivotal points of this cyclical journey.

5.1 The Circle of Harm Tolerance

When asked to describe the experience of using dating apps, users frequently use metaphors such as shopping and gaming, as highlighted by multiple researchers (Heino et al., 2010; Huang et al., 2022). Consistent with existing literature, this study also found that market and game-related metaphors dominated how users describe dating apps. However, the most revealing finding was the presence of labor metaphors. 23.88% used a labor-related description when prompted to provide a metaphor. Users tend to define online dating as something that requires effort. There is a meaningful difference in describing an experience as “finding clothes in a thrift store” and “trying to find breathable oxygen in space.” The first describes an activity, and the second describes the mental toll.

The intensity of the cost of participation becomes more visible when we understand what drives these metaphorical explanations by looking into the harms users experience while being part of the dating ecosystem. In accordance with existing literature (Bates et al., 2023; Choi et al., 2018; Echevarria et al., 2023; Gewirtz-Meydan et al., 2024), 52% of all participants said they have experienced at least one kind of harm on-app or in-person, and female and other sexual minorities are more vulnerable to harm in dating apps. The most jarring example of someone bringing a gun on a date was experienced by a queer female.

What follows harm is underreporting. We found that 71% of the respondents who have faced harm say they have never reported any incident on the dating app, and this figure is consistent with the Australian report that found only 21.5% of victims reported to the platforms (Lawler & Boxall, 2023). This aligns with existing literature suggesting that users believe that blocking or reporting bad actors is ineffective (Krueger, 2015; Gillett, 2023), raising the question: if users are not reporting on the platforms where they face the harms, what are they doing instead?

This study points to rationalization as an answer to that question. There seems to be a distinction between perceived safety and actual safety, and this gap seems to widen the longer someone is on the platform. Users report experiencing in-app and in-person harm, feeling safe using the apps and meeting people from there, and this perceived sense of safety increases with the duration of use. Even though this pattern seems counterintuitive at first, it reflects the normalization process, where their baseline expectation of what is acceptable behavior on the platform shifts with repeated exposure. It is also possible that long-term users may have developed a personal coping mechanism (Gillett, 2023; Pruchniewska, 2020), like selective disclosure or filtering, that gives them a subjective sense of control.

This distinction between perceived and actual safety shows that the ecosystem feels safer, even if it is not actually safe, and users are actively involved in this rationalization process. But what drives this rationalization?

It appears users rationalize the harms they experience as a way of staying in an ecosystem, as users feel like they can not leave. This study was able to show that harm and satisfaction are not mutually exclusive in how users relate to dating apps; instead, they hold both truths at once. Digging into the co-existence of positive and negative feelings by looking at responses to contrasting questions, (for example dating apps feel like a chore but are also enjoyable), demonstrates that users can have general agreement to two statements that should be contradictory, revealing an interesting tension: they recognize that they have experienced harm on dating apps, yet tend not to report those harms. They feel safe using dating apps and meeting people they meet on a dating app, yet simultaneously find the experience is enjoyable and chore-like.

The nuance of this complex relationship between experiencing harm and rationalizing is revealed in Reddit data. The idea of blocking or reporting as an “overreaction” (Gillett, 2023) is more visible in Reddit, even with a handful of posts. Out of 4,395 total Reddit posts, only 6 explicitly mentioned reporting another user. Posts that mention reporting are often filled with self-doubt. Titles like “Did I do the right thing?”, “What do I do?” suggests that users often do not feel entitled to decide on their own safety and instead seek external validation to decide on personal safety. This means users are not turning to the platform to resolve harm but turning to themselves or the community. This indicates the belief that personal navigation can manage their experience without platforms’ direct involvement. This belief is where the illusion of control begins.

For a user who believes that their action determines the matching outcome, to call themselves “*a product on a shelf at the store*” is not a consistent framing of agency. While apps go all-in in the

process of datafication of intimacy, this act of engaging with the app through prompts and pictures, and the general understanding that there exists an algorithm that validates the matches, makes people feel like they have agency over their matches (De Ridder, 2022).

However, as Langlais and Lee discussed, young adults might not view dating apps as helpful to form relationships (Langlais & Lee, 2025). This push and pull of agency and lack of faith that the system will work for you shows up in the study when we look at how people talk about agency in the Likert question (Figure 9) and metaphorical description. This conflict of being a part of the platform without faith that the platform will work in your favor might lead people to come up with strategies to optimize their experience in the app (Alizadeh et al., 2024). This study found that users use more communal strategies like seeking advice online through profile review posts, sharing tips and tricks that appear to get people better matches, and more community-driven strategies to improve dating outcomes. This operationalization of illusion puts all the burden on the users and becomes a substitute for holding platforms accountable.

While literature talks about how seeking advice on Reddit might be a coping strategy for men due to the pressure of gender expectations of assertion (Sobieraj & Humphreys, 2022), it can be thought of as a personal effort to use an online community to get a desired response from a platform. It also raises questions about how opaque the platform must feel, where your ultimate resort to any success is to post your entire profile with a caption of “Am I doing something wrong?” by exposing yourself on an anonymous platform. This prevalence of profile review posts, as shown in Figure 11, aligns closely with the pattern of perceived agency/control observed in Figure 9. Since users believe that their own actions determine their matching

outcomes, when the outcomes are unsatisfactory, they look inward and turn to a community to improve their self-presentation rather than questioning the platforms.

The illusion of control also shapes how people behave outside of dating platforms and creates a market around this illusion. Platforms like profilehelper.com and agoodfirstdate.com are built around the idea of control, that users can make the platform give them what they want if they use their tool. While the literature does not yet comprehensively study this category of services, their existence is an indication that there is more space in the ‘marketplace of hope’, which dating apps dominate. With the rise of AI, users are already uncertain about what counts as authentic on the platforms, as 44% of participants believed that others use AI to write prompts, but only 19% admitted to doing so, and that number drops as it gets to more intimate forms of self-presentation, like starting a conversation or posting a picture. This self-exemption pattern suggests that regardless of what kind of help users seek to build their profile (Reddit, GenAI), they tend to think their profile reflects genuine effort, while others might not. Regardless of whether AI displaces profile writing tools or makes this market more dystopian with services like AI dating simulators, the intersection of perceived sense of control, Reddit, or AI-assisted authenticity warrants further attention.

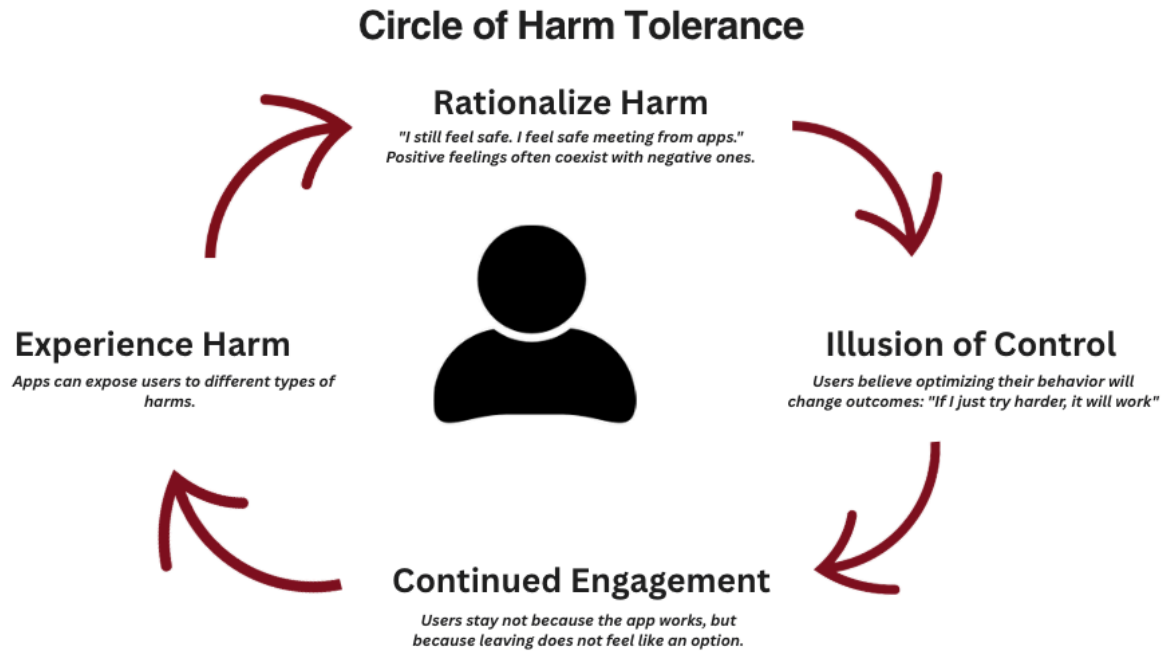


Figure 15: Circle of Harm Tolerance: how users experience harm, find ways to rationalize that harm by tapping into their illusion of control, and continue engaging on the platform by tweaking their behavior in the hope of better platform outcomes.

Despite this uncertainty about authenticity, algorithmic opacity, and a profit-driven marketplace, users keep engaging with the platforms. Browsing profiles without initiating interaction and maintaining profiles but rarely initiating contact seems to be another popular way young people are using dating apps. This highlights a more passive way of being part of the dating ecosystem. While lurking in social media platforms is more common (Rau et al., 2008; Liu et al., 2024), online dating might seem less prone to lurking, which can explain the research gap. However, as Liu (2024) suggests, fatigue and anxiety play a role in lurking behavior online, and as users experience more harm in online dating platforms, they might be more passive.

This study highlighted that 83% of all survey respondents had taken a break from a dating platform. These breaks suggest that even though users rationalize harms on online dating sites, they are affected by it, and taking a break can be a way to switch out of it. However, people explained that they kept coming back to dating platforms. Reddit data adds another layer to this pattern that returning users consistently show higher negative sentiments compared to other users across all three sentiment classification methods. This suggests that returning users are not in a neutral state like first-time users and carry the weight of their past experiences. In such a scenario, passive engagement with the platforms might be the way users cope with the harms and opacity of the platform, because leaving the platform completely might feel like giving up on their love life, as the options to meet people beyond dating apps are very limited (Rosenfeld et al., 2019). So the hope sustained by the illusion of control is what keeps the cycle moving.

5.2 Implications for the platform

This disconnect between the platform and users reveals the gap between how the platform approaches user safety and how users approach personal safety. The psychological toll documented in literature (Gewirtz-Meydan et al., 2024) could potentially explain users' tendency to rationalize harm rather than take action. This highlights the need to study perceived safety and actual safety associated with dating apps. Platforms cannot assume users will report harms; the system they build needs to account for times when users don't. If platforms want to close the gap between perceived and actual safety, they need to make an effort for proactive detection, clearly communicate what reporting achieves, and set visible consequences for bad actors on the platform. As users indicate using multiple platforms at the same time, platforms need to make an active effort so that bad actors are not able to switch platforms easily.

While platform interventions like “Are you sure?” make a proactive effort to nudge users not to use problematic pickup lines, they have their limits, as the purpose is not to make the conversation inauthentic by censoring users. However, users who are on the receiving end of those texts think that either reporting does nothing or that they are not entitled to report someone and seek validation and guidance from external communities like Reddit to decide on personal safety. If platforms are building safety interventions to keep users safe, and users are still turning to Reddit to decide whether their issue is serious enough to report, then those interventions are not landing successfully.

This study sheds light on the prevalence of harm and means of rationalization. Further research needs to be done with a more extensive harm taxonomy that looks at different hierarchies of harms. Additionally, further research can also help us understand how users experience harms at different levels, respond to those harms, and try to draw the line between user agency and the need for platform interventions. This is important because for issues such as unwanted messages and unsolicited pictures, users can block or unmatched other users. However, when a user’s actions affect other users beyond direct interaction through things like fake profiles, trying to hack banning, the burden of intervention may shift to platforms.

Though it might seem like an illusion of control is a user problem, it unpacks the platform design problem. When platforms are opaque, users act based on their perceived understanding of the algorithm (Alizadeh et al., 2024). This creates a space for platforms to be more transparent and

to close the gap between them and the users. If not, there is a chance that users will continue to mistake platform affordances they are given for the control they do not have.

5.3 Implications for the users

The cycle of harm tolerance is not inevitable, but for a user to be able to break out of this cycle, they need to distinguish between what they can and cannot control. As shown by both the survey and Reddit discussions, users direct all their energy towards self-optimization of a system they vaguely understand. The sheer existence of profile review threads, where people actively post their picture and profile in a platform like Reddit, whose core appeal is being anonymous, reinforces the idea that users tend to attribute poor matching outcomes to personal shortcomings and focus on self-correction rather than holding platforms accountable.

As highlighted by this study, when asked about the good aspect of dating apps, 72.5% of the respondents said it is the access to people that the platform provides. This highlights the lack of other alternatives for people to meet potential partners. This further complicates the relationship between the platform and users. As users' experience on the platform gets poorer, they recalibrate their harm tolerance and platform expectation, which creates this middle ground where they lurk on the platform without any participation. This subset of users who are not actively engaged but still dependent on access to leave the platform entirely resort to passive participation. This feeling of being stuck is what the circle of harm tolerance represents. If fatigue and anxiety drive lurking as Liu (2024) suggests, then users should take it as a signal that something about the experience needs to change; it can be taking a genuine break, adjusting expectations, or even seeking other alternatives.

While some users choose passive lurking, profile review is the other extreme, where users enthusiastically engage with profile optimization. Even though they look so different, both actions are the result of being stuck in an ecosystem that is not working for you. Both *strategies* allow users to stay in the ecosystem without challenging it.

Through the use of the circle of harm tolerance, this study was able to highlight that the relationship between users and platforms is not limited to individual experience of harm or dissatisfaction, but there is a cycle that affects them both and does not benefit either. Users are stuck in a circle of expectation, harm, rationalization, illusion, and returning to the platform. In this study, we were able to highlight this circle in the context of young users who are just entering this ecosystem through the survey, and also users who are actively part of this ecosystem through Reddit discourse. Further research is needed to study this cycle longitudinally with more expansive harm taxonomies and attention to how the intensity of these experiences evolves.

6. Limitations

This study has several limitations that need to be noted. Firstly, the survey relied on convenience sampling, and all of the data comes from just Cornell students who did the survey for extra credit. Cornell students are not representative of the average dating app user. Since the survey among Cornell students was done for extra credit, even though it was fully anonymous, it is possible that students just gave acceptable answers instead of honest responses.

On the Reddit side, there is a strict limit on the total number of posts that can be extracted, so the discourse we analyzed is limited by what we could scrape. A 2023 study done by the University of Edinburgh found that the majority of Reddit users are twice as likely to be men as women (Vuorio & Horne, 2023). So the data we got from Reddit might represent mostly men. As earlier research that uses Reddit notes has shown, there is no way for us to verify if the Reddit post is authentic or true. The subreddits were picked based on activity and their size; it is possible that there are other subreddits where different kinds of discourse are happening. The audience for both survey and Reddit skews young users predominantly from 18-25; it is possible that the opinion and experience of older adults using dating apps might be very different than what we captured in this study.

This study was limited by the sample size, the demographics of survey respondents, and the self-selected users who participated in the ten subreddits that were sampled. Further research should take that into account and observe if a similar sense of agency can also be observed in older users. However, despite this limitation, this study employed multiple data collection and data analysis methods, and the results point towards the Circle of Harm Tolerance framework. This framework offers a starting point to connect multiple dimensions of the platform-user relationship. Further study can hopefully build on top of this framework to understand the nuances more clearly.

7. Conclusion

Dating is complicated, but more complicated than that is the relationship between dating platforms and users. Through the use of a Likert scale, open-ended questions in the survey, and keyword match and sentiment analysis in Reddit, this study highlights the nuance of this complicated relationship. Moving beyond satisfaction and dissatisfaction with the platforms, we were able to uncover the cyclical nature of user experience: users experience harm, rationalize it, sustain an illusion of control, and continue engaging with the platforms.

While existing literature mostly focuses on a single aspect of a user experience, either access, harm, or metaphors, this study brings all the pieces together to paint a more complete picture of the user experience. We were able to trace how these different aspects connect and reinforce each other. The Circle of Harm Tolerance offers a framework for understanding that users are not idle in this partnership. In fact, they make an active effort to rationalize and optimize their self-presentation on the platform. User effort is significantly dedicated to self-improvement over holding platforms accountable.

Our study was able to shed light on the complicated stages of rationalization and illusion of control the user goes through when they become a part of a dating platform. The gap between perceived and actual safety was clearly displayed. The fact that perceived safety increases over time warrants attention from future researchers to dig into what drives this perception.

Underreporting and self-improvement were other big themes that reflect the distance between platforms and users. The illusion of control highlights both the user agency issue and platform design problems at the same time. Users appear to navigate algorithmic opacity by focusing on self-optimization, which has created another ecosystem of third-party services (for example,

services that promise profile improvement). As the ubiquity of AI increases, researchers should also pay attention to how users will use AI to further reinforce their perceived sense of control. While the technology is evolving, it is very likely that this core tension won't change. Because even in platforms designed to be deleted, the reality is that users can't seem to leave.

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Appendix

A. Metaphor Keyword to Theme Mapping

Concept Map

Concept	Keywords
shopping	shop, store, supermarket, buying, catalog, catalogue, amazon, shelf, product, market
restaurant/food	restaurant, menu, dish, buffet, chocolate, grocery, farmers market, snack
fishing/hunting	fish, fishing, hunter, hunting, cast, net, sea
needle_haystack	needle, haystack, forest, tree
browsing	browse, browsing, scroll, swiping, swipe
library/books	library, book, bookstore, cover
sorting/sifting	sort, sift, rummage, thrift
puzzle	puzzle
gambling/lottery	gambl, lottery, dart, throw, slot
game	game, candy crush, video game, playing
job/interview	job, interview, recruit, venture capital, vc
marketplace/transaction	marketplace, transact
choices/options	option, choice, pick, select
mystery/unknown	box, never know, mystery, unknown, surprise, unpredictable, random, chance, luck, unexpected, hit or miss
appearance/visual	picture, profile, cover, look, appear
testing/trying	test, try, experiment, trial, work, effort, get what you put
maze/complexity	maze, swamp, complicated, confusing, lost
crowd/overwhelming	crowd, blind, overwhelming
easy_access	easy, convenient, accessible, low hanging fruit
casual/boredom	side, bored, pass time, kill time, nothing to do
modern_equivalent	modern, equivalent, 20 years ago, nowadays, today

netflix/streaming	netflix, show, streaming
social_media	social media
exhausting/draining	exhaust, drain, tiring, tire, worn out, energy
frustrating	frustrate, annoying, irritate
disappointing	disappoint, let down, letdown, unsatisfying, hopeless
invalidating	invalidat, self-doubt, confidence, self-worth, self-esteem
negative_general	suck, terrible, awful, bad, horrible, weird, strange, odd
unreliable/luck	unreliable, inconsistent, unpredictable, unstable
waiting	wait, waiting room
journey	journey
balloon	balloon
waste	waste, time
pool	pool
airport	airport
void	void
nest	nest
scary/threatening	shark, scary, dangerous, threat
injustice	injustice, unfair
desperate	desperate, desperation
fake/misleading	fake, broken label, misleading, incomplete, deceptive

Higher Order Theme

Higher_Order_Theme	Concepts
consumer_economy	shopping, restaurant/food, marketplace/transaction, easy_access
search_discovery	fishing/hunting, needle_haystack, browsing, sorting/sifting, library/books, puzzle
game_chance	gambling/lottery, game, mystery/unknown

labor_effort	job/interview, testing/trying, exhausting/draining
entertainment_media	netflix/streaming, social_media, casual/boredom
negative_emotional	frustrating, disappointing, invalidating, negative_general, waste
confusing_difficult	maze/complexity, unreliable, crowd/overwhelming
passive_waiting	waiting, void, pool
choice_abundance	choices/options
surface_judgment	appearance/visual
journey_process	journey
threatening_unsafe	scary/threatening, injustice, desperate, fake/misleading
modern_context	modern_equivalent

Higher Order Theme	Dominant Theme
consumer_economy	market
choice_abundance	market
surface_judgment	market
game_chance	game_chance
entertainment_media	game_chance
passive_waiting	game_chance
labor_effort	labor
search_discovery	labor
negative_emotional	negative
threatening_unsafe	negative
confusing_difficult	negative

B. Reddit Duration of App Use Mapping

Output labels

Labels	Assigned when
returning user	Text contains a returning/reinstall phrase
early user	Contains an explicit "new user" phrase or a time expression < 30 days of app usage
using for a few months	Time expression ≥ 30 days and < 365 days of app usage
using for at least a year	Time expression ≥ 365 days of app usage
no reference to use time	None of the above matches

Labels and Keywords:

Label	Keywords
App usage anchor phrases	"been on," "been here," "been using," "on this app," "on the app," "using this app," "using the app," "on here," "here for," "downloaded," "installed," "joined"
Returning user phrases	"came back," "back on," "back again," "reinstalled," "re-downloaded," "deleted and came back," "returned to," "new account," "second account"
New/early user phrases (explicit)	"new here," "just joined," "just downloaded," "just installed," "day 1," "first day," "just started," "signed up today," "downloaded today"

Time Regex Match

Group	Pattern / Expression	Rough Day Estimate	Label
Short	(\d+) days	exact number of days	early users
Short	a week	7	early users
Short	(\d+) weeks	weeks $\times$ 7	early users
Short	a few weeks	21	early users
Medium	a month	30	using for a few months
Medium	a few months	90	using for a few months
Medium	a couple of months	60	using for a few months
Medium	several months	150	using for a few months
Medium	(\d+) months	months $\times$ 30	using for a few months
Long	over a year	400	using for at least a year
Long	almost a year	340	using for a few months
Long	a year	365	using for at least a year
Long	(\d+(\.\d+)?) years	years $\times$ 365	using for at least a year

C. Negative Keyword Matching for Triangulation

Negative Stems	exhaust, crush, polluted, cattle, endless, needle, gambl, slot, soul-crush, marathon, disappoint, waste, frustrat, terrible, awful, suck, bad, horrible, fake, misleading, superficial, shallow, scary, weird, drain, unreliable, inconsistent, hopeless
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D. Keyword Matching for Responses to the “What Do Dating Apps Do Right?”

Category	Keywords
Algorithm	algorithm, algorithm, algorithms, algorithms, match, matching, matches, compatible, compatibility, suggest, recommend, preference, filter, curate, learn, smart, personalize, personalised, personalizing, tailored, sort, rank, interest, profile, based, similar, like-minded, system, score, fit, suited, prompt, prompts, fun prompts, pictures, photos, post, technology, design, app design
Safety	safe, safety, secure, security, verify, verified, verification, report, block, protect, protection, privacy, private, identity, real, background, flag, moderate, moderation, trust, screen, screening, fake, catfish, photo verify, id check, standardization
Validation	validate, validation, confidence, confident, esteem, self-esteem, boost, like, liked, match notification, attention, feel good, attractive, attractiveness, desirable, wanted, compliment, feedback, ego, reassure, reassurance, positive, affirmation, affirm, worth, value, gamification, experience
Access	access, pool, network, networking, reach, wide, large, quantity, diversity, majority, number, meet, connect, find, discover, browse, swipe, friend, friends, city, easy, convenience, convenient, platform, available, space, creating space, people, anyone, everyone, many, options, choice, variety, single, fun, entertainment, interactive, location, proximity, near, distance, exposure, expand, opportunities, show